

HELD GROUND

The King's Crusade — Module Eight

OVERVIEW

Vindana is held, the coalition is exhausted in the specific, good way an army gets after a fight it won, and this module's entire job is to let that feeling breathe before the campaign asks anything hard of the party again. There is no required plot beat here. A second member of the royal house is found and freed along the way, but it happens inside the same relaxed, comic register as everything else in this module rather than as inserted business. Core scenes run three to three and a half hours; this is one of the few modules in the

campaign where running short is not a problem — let the table linger.

LEVITY, PLANNED IN

CLAUDE.md is explicit that this campaign's relief valves are designed, not accidental, and this module is where that design shows up structurally. Play every scene here for warmth first: reunions, absurd logistics, recurring characters getting real room. If a DM feels the urge to raise the stakes, resist it — Module Nine will do that job. This one's job is rest.

Scene	Target time	Notes
1. The Long Exhale	45–60 min	Vindana at rest. Recurring characters welcome.
2. The Grain Ledger War	30–45 min	Absurd logistics. Comedy, not combat.
3. The Magistrate	60–75 min	The second rescue, played as a caper. DC table below.
4. What the Name Costs	20–30 min	A quiet scene with Xavier. Closes the module.
Optional Content	30–45 min	Run if the table has time; cut cleanly if not.

WHAT IS ACTUALLY HAPPENING (DM ONLY)

Nothing in this module is a trap, a test, or a delayed complication. Vindana is genuinely secure, the coalition is genuinely at ease for the first time since Module One, and the Magistrate's rescue in Scene 3 is genuinely as easy as it plays — the occupation's administration in a freshly-fallen city is in real disarray, and a party willing to use its own paperwork against it will find that disarray works entirely in their favor. If a DM feels this module is too easy, that is correct and intentional.

DM Only: Xavier has still not directly addressed being called the Wyvernheart as of this module's start — the gap held open in Module Seven continues into Scene 4, which is the one place this module allows real feeling. Do not let the earlier scenes anticipate it.

SCENE 1: THE LONG EXHALE

Vindana's taken harbor district has become, within days, the loudest and most cheerful place the coalition has occupied since Harrowmark. Let the party spend real time here.

Someone has chalked a running tally on the side of a captured warehouse — days since the siege, casks emptied, and, unofficially, a tally of how many times a passing soldier has tried and failed to get a straight answer out of Huntmaster Brenna Vane about whether she actually rode south for the war or just to see the fuss for herself.

If Module One was played, Brenna Vane has arrived with a handful of Greywatch hands, drawn south by rumor of the Wyvernheart with an expression that suggests she will never admit that is the reason. If Module 2A or 2B was played, Sera Vosk or Garrick Hollow can likewise turn up here, already embedded in the coalition's logistics or scouting corps. Use whichever recurring faces the table has earned; this scene's only job is reunion and warmth.

SCENE 2: THE GRAIN LEDGER WAR

Vindana's occupation-era grain levy records — thousands of receipts, quotas, and permits, exactly the bureaucracy Module Three showed the party in miniature — have fallen into coalition hands whole, and nobody sent to sort them was remotely prepared for the scale of it.

Three different coalition quartermasters are shouting at each other over a single warehouse of requisitioned grain, each one certain their own contingent's paperwork takes precedence, while an increasingly desperate Elduvish clerk — pressed into the coalition's service rather than freed from it, which nobody seems to have noticed yet — tries to explain that the numbers do not actually add up for anyone.

Let the party resolve this however they find funniest: mediate, cut through it with authority, or simply steal a

wagon of grain themselves while the argument continues. No mechanical stakes and no wrong answer. If a perceptive party notices the pressed clerk's situation and does something about it — a small kindness, not a rescue — let that pay forward into how Elduvaine's ordinary people regard the coalition later.

SCENE 3: THE MAGISTRATE

Among the captured administration's own records is a name the party will recognize if they have been paying attention: a second member of the royal house, held not in a dungeon but under a kind of house arrest in a minor Vindana townhouse, kept comfortable and thoroughly bored by an occupation too disorganized, post-siege, to know quite what to do with her.

The Magistrate — nobody has ever heard her called anything else, including, apparently, herself — receives the party with the weary patience of someone who has spent three years winning arguments with clerks half her age. “You’ll want papers,” she says, before anyone has explained themselves. “Everybody wants papers. Fortunately, I have spent three years becoming extremely good at papers.”

Task	Skill	DC	Tier
Resolve the quartermasters' dispute without violence	Persuasion / Insight	10	Easy
Forge or produce convincing transfer papers	Deception / an appropriate tool proficiency	13	Moderate
Talk a guard out of scrutinizing the papers	Persuasion	10	Easy
Notice the pressed Elduvish clerk's actual situation	Insight / Perception	13	Moderate

SCENE 4: WHAT THE NAME COSTS

Late, with the day's business done, Xavier finds the party somewhere quiet — away from the harbor's noise, away from anyone keeping official record of the conversation.

“They’ve started calling me something,” he says, not quite a question. “I keep waiting for someone to explain it to me properly and nobody will. I remember the dragon. I remember being fairly sure I was about to die. I don’t remember deciding to be brave about it — I remember being too frightened to think of anything else to do.” He is quiet for a moment. “Is that what the songs are going to say happened? Because I’d rather they didn’t, if it’s all the same.”

Let this be a real conversation rather than a scene to resolve. Xavier is not fishing for reassurance and does not need the party to tell him he is a hero; he genuinely does not know yet how he feels about the name, and the party's honest reaction — whatever it is — matters more here than any mechanical outcome. This scene needs no check and produces no loot. It is the module's actual point, arriving last, exactly where CLAUDE.md's instruction to plan levity in on purpose has been building since Scene 1.

RUNNING THE SCENE

This is a caper, not a fight. The Magistrate's household is guarded by a skeleton crew of occupation clerks and one or two soldiers, none of them expecting trouble in a freshly-fallen city, and she herself is entirely capable of walking out the front door if the party can produce (or forge) plausible transfer papers — Vindana's administrative chaos, established in Scene 2, means nobody is checking closely. A DC 13 Deception or Forgery-adjacent check (use whatever tool proficiency a character has) produces convincing papers; a DC 10 Persuasion check talks a guard into not looking too hard at them regardless.

If the party would rather simply walk in and take her by force, that works too and is considerably less interesting — a DM should let the Magistrate herself gently steer the party toward the caper option if asked, since she has clearly been planning her own exit for some time and has opinions about the tidiest way to manage it.

TIERED SKILL DCs

Easy 10, Moderate 13, Hard 16, matching the tiers used throughout this campaign.

NPC PROFILES

THE MAGISTRATE

Elderly, dry, and entirely unbroken by three years of house arrest — if anything, sharpened by it. Speech: precise, faintly amused, allergic to being underestimated. Where the Ward met her captivity with fury, the Magistrate met hers with bureaucratic warfare, and won more of it than her captors ever noticed.

Open thread: freed, she is a formidable and very funny recurring NPC — a DM can use her as a source of administrative chaos turned against the occupation in any later module, or simply as comic relief who happens to also be dangerous in exactly the way nobody expects from an old woman with a ledger.

OPTIONAL CONTENT

THE BETTING LEDGER RETURNS

If Module One was played and Brenna Vane is present per Scene 1, her old betting ledger from Greywatch makes a reappearance, now taking wagers on considerably higher-stakes nonsense — how long the peace will hold, whether the

Magistrate and the Ward will get along, anything the table finds funny. Pure levity, no stakes.

A QUIET WORD WITH THE WARD

If the Ward was rescued in Module Four, let her and the Magistrate meet for the first time here — two members of a divided royal house with different ideas about what should follow the war, meeting in a moment that has no pressure on it yet. Play their first exchange for warmth and a little friction, not conflict; save the real disagreement for later in the campaign, per the royal house's established canon division on the question.

DIVERGING PATHS (DM ONLY)

- **How the Magistrate was freed.** Caper or force — track which. A caper leaves the occupation's administration none the wiser for a while longer, which a DM can use later; a forced rescue is noisier and gives the coalition's presence in Vindana a slightly harder edge sooner.
- **Whether the party noticed the pressed clerk in Scene 2.** A small thread, but worth tracking — it is the campaign's recurring question about the occupation's ordinary people, in miniature, again.

LOOT

- **The Magistrate herself.** As with the Ward in Module Four, the module's actual reward — a second freed royal, formidable in her own register, and a second real voice in whatever the royal house eventually decides about Elduvaine's future.
- **A warehouse's worth of grain.** However the Grain Ledger War was resolved, the coalition ends this module better supplied than it started it — modest, practical, not a coin windfall.

THE REFRAIN

*By thought, and by word, and by deed,
the king's own chosen kept their creed.
Far from home, where the quiet land lay,
they held the line, and would not stray.*